inheritance upon the death of a wealthy relative or courtier. Hamida Banu had requested that her fortune be divided between her male descendants.

At the death of Hamida Banu, we are told in the *Akbarnama*, the harem was in complete disarray. And we may believe the truth behind this as the women grieved for this remarkable matriarch of the Timurids, the last of them. All her life she had been unconstrained by the changing norms which required women to be invisible and voiceless. From the time she had jumped onto the horse which had carried her to Persia alongside Humayun, Hamida Banu, fiercely independent, had never stopped journeying according to her whims and her spirit. She was often to be found unexpectedly setting out from a capital, accompanied by her constant companion, Gulbadan, to surprise her son on one of his campaigns or hunts. While Akbar and the court had spent long years in Lahore, Hamida Banu waited, undaunted, in Fatehpur Sikri, tending to her affairs and travelling relentlessly between the two imperial cities. On his part, Akbar had accommodated her every desire and had gloried in worshipping her publicly, like he would the Divine.

Now, for the second time in his life, Akbar shaved his hair and moustache, in the manner of the Hindus, and all his courtiers followed suit. Akbar set the bier of his mother's body upon his shoulder, and carried it out of the city whence it journeyed, for the last time, to Delhi, to be buried in the family mausoleum of Humayun's tomb. At the end of the day, Akbar came out of his chamber and stood quietly for a moment; the servants were surprised by his pensive and calm demeanour. It is impossible to know the Padshah's thoughts as he watched the storm clouds gather over Agra and contemplated the loss of another indispensable figure from his life. He had lost many of the men and women who had accompanied his turbulent journey through more than sixty years of turmoil and grace. Only Salima Sultan Begum, Ruqaiya Begum, and Aziz Koka, from the old guard, remained at court. Now there was a new generation of Mughals, especially the princes Khusrau and Khurram, who accompanied their grandfather everywhere, and witnessed his terrible, corrosive rage at the disobedience of their father.

In November 1604, Salim finally decided to present himself at court, to offer his condolences to his father and to assess the depth of the Padshah's disaffection. Salim would write in his memoirs that this was one of the decisions he was most proud of, despite determined opposition from his